

Toughest test yet: With Savita Punia likely to miss the upcoming Asia Cup in China due to an ankle injury, Bichu Devi will take on the mantle of guarding the goal. PICS: HOCKEYINDIA



THE RELUCTANT GUARDIAN

A twist of fate and father's advice turned a football-mad teenager into India's **next hope** under the crossbar.

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Bichu Devi was in sharp form during a training session at the SAI centre in Bengaluru.

"You want a break, Bichu?" asked Dave Smolenaars, the Indian women's

hockey team's analytical coach. "No, coach," the goalkeeper replied.

Watching from the dugout was Savita Punia, India's mainstay in goal for almost two decades, her foot in a boot due to an ankle injury. The former captain sustained it during

the FIH Pro League and is likely to miss the upcoming Asia Cup in China.

In the senior's absence, Bichu will have to step up and take on the mantle of guarding the goal — and, as it turns out, Savita had already prepared her for it.

"The day she got her reports and